



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 593 Amendment 1 Vessel Modifications – pre-approval by MCA

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1. Introduction/background

1.1 Fishing Vessels are required to ensure that, prior to modifications being carried out on their vessel, they seek MCA approval to ensure that safety of the vessel is not affected. This approval should be sought regardless of whether these modifications are being undertaken with or without funding.

2. Requirements of the Codes of Practice

2.1 The requirements regarding MCA approval of vessel modifications are contained the following Statutory Instrument and Codes of Practice:

- The Fishing Vessels (Codes of Practice) Regulations 2017 No.943
- MSN 1871 (F) Amendment No.2 The Code of Practice for the Safety of Fishing Vessels of less than 15m Length Overall (LOA)
- MSN 1872 (F) Amendment No.1 The Code of Practice for the Construction and Use of Fishing Vessels of 15m LOA to less than 24m Registered Length (L)
- MSN 1873 (F) Amendment No.1 The Code of Practice for the Construction and Use of Fishing Vessels of 24m (L) and Over

2.2 The Codes require that substantial modifications, either funded through grants or other means; or alterations affecting the vessel's dimensions, structure or stability; the removal or repositioning of machinery or engines; changes in the vessel's mode of fishing and/or its gear; or the fitting of additional equipment, shall be investigated prior to making any changes, to ensure that the vessel will continue to comply with the required stability criteria. In addition, such modifications or alterations to any vessel shall only be carried out after consultation and with the approval of the MCA.

3. Advice to applicants for funding

3.1 By approaching the MCA prior to applying for funding, owners can ensure they:

- incorporate any amendments to the proposed modifications that the MCA may require into the application; and
- obtain MCA approval to proceed with the modification.

3.2 If, at the time you submit your application for funding, you are able to provide the MMO or your Devolved Administration with evidence that you have informed the MCA of your proposed modifications or have had them approved, this can provide evidence that your proposed modification has been considered for safety or is in the process of being considered. MCA surveyors can provide this evidence in a standard format.

3.3 The Fishing Vessels (Codes of Practice) Regulations 2017 state that if work commences on a modification without MCA approval, the owner is at risk of the Certificate being suspended whilst the MCA conducts an inspection or survey of the vessel. The MCA may require amendments to the intended modifications or potentially the vessel to be reinstated to its original condition. This work may not be covered by additional funding.

3.4 For this reason, it is particularly important that owners approach the MCA prior to submitting an application for funding to minimise the risk of the vessel being suspended from fishing and from having to undertake additional work to address the vessel's safety.

3.5 The table at [Annex A \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/min-593-f-amendment-1-vessel-modifications-pre-approval-by-mca\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/min-593-f-amendment-1-vessel-modifications-pre-approval-by-mca) shows the items that are commonly applied for. This list is NOT comprehensive. If the items you intend to apply for funding for are not included on this list or you are unsure if your item needs pre-approval, based on the requirements of the Code as set out in section 2.2 above, you should also contact the MCA prior to submitting an application.

4. Contact Details

4.1 Up to date contact details for MCA Marine Offices can be found on the [access and opening times page](#)

(<https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/maritime-and-coastguard-agency/about/access-and-opening>) on gov.uk.

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Please note that all addresses and telephone numbers are correct at time of publishing.

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